Classical Dance Forms of India

Introduction to Indian Classical Dance

Indian classical dance is a group of highly developed, codified dance traditions that tell stories from mythology, literature and life through rhythmic movement, expressive faces, hand gestures and music. Most are based on the Natya Shastra, an ancient Sanskrit treatise on drama, dance and music attributed to the sage Bharata Muni, composed between about 200 BCE and 200 CE. The Natya Shastra describes the nine rasas, or emotions: shringara (love), hasya (laughter), karuna (compassion), raudra (anger), veera (courage), bhayanaka (fear), bibhatsa (disgust), adbhuta (wonder) and shanta (peace). Classical dance is usually divided into nritta (pure dance movement and rhythm), nritya (expressive dance with emotion and meaning, using hand gestures and facial expressions) and natya (dramatic storytelling). Two basic modes are tandava, vigorous and masculine, and lasya, graceful and soft.

How Many Classical Dances Are Officially Recognised?

Eight classical dance forms are officially recognised by the Sangeet Natak Akademi, the National Academy of Music, Dance and Drama in India: Bharatanatyam, Kathak, Kuchipudi, Odissi, Kathakali, Sattriya, Manipuri and Mohiniyattam. Sattriya from Assam was the last to be added, in 2000. The Ministry of Culture also includes Chhau, a martial and mask dance of eastern India, in its list, bringing the number to nine in some official lists, though the Akademi recognises eight. Each dance is associated with a particular region: Bharatanatyam with Tamil Nadu, Kathak with north India, Kuchipudi with Andhra Pradesh, Odissi with Odisha, Kathakali and Mohiniyattam with Kerala, Manipuri with Manipur and Sattriya with Assam.

Which Dance Form Comes From Tamil Nadu?

Bharatanatyam is the classical dance of Tamil Nadu. It is one of the oldest and most popular classical dance forms, with roots in the temple dance traditions called Sadir or Dasiattam, performed by devadasis in temples of Tamil Nadu. The name is often explained as Bha (bhava, expression), Ra (raga, melody), Ta (tala, rhythm) and Natyam (dance). Its roots are described in ancient Tamil literature, such as the epic Silappatikaram, and the sculptures in the Nataraja temple at Chidambaram show the 108 karanas, or dance units, described in the Natya Shastra. In the early 19th century, the Thanjavur Quartet, four brothers named Ponnaiah, Chinnaiah, Sivanandam and Vadivelu, systematised the Bharatanatyam repertoire. In the 20th century the art was revived and restored to respectability through the efforts of E. Krishna Iyer, Rukmini Devi Arundale, who founded Kalakshetra in Chennai in 1936, and the great dancer T. Balasaraswati. Features of Bharatanatyam include the aramandi, a half-sitting position with bent knees, rhythmic footwork, sharp geometric lines, precise hand gestures and expressive eyes and face. A traditional performance, the margam, includes items such as alarippu, jatiswaram, shabdam, varnam, padam and tillana. The first public stage performance by a student is called the arangetram. Costumes include a pleated silk sari, temple jewellery and ankle bells called salangai. Accompanying music is Carnatic, with the nattuvanar conducting the rhythm. Famous Bharatanatyam dancers include Padma Subrahmanyam, Yamini Krishnamurthy, Alarmel Valli and Sudharani Raghupathy.

What Is a Mudra?

A mudra is a symbolic hand gesture used in Indian dance, yoga, meditation and religious art to express a meaning, an object or an emotion. In classical dance, mudras, also called hastas, are an important part of abhinaya, the art of expression, and they help the dancer to tell a story without words. Texts such as the Abhinaya Darpana by Nandikeshvara describe 28 single-hand gestures (asamyuta hastas), such as pataka (flag), tripataka, ardhachandra (half moon), mayura (peacock), alapadma (lotus), and 24 double-hand gestures (samyuta hastas), such as anjali and kartarimukha. For example, in Bharatanatyam, the Pataka mudra, with the fingers held straight together, can mean a river, a wind or a flag, while the Hamsasya may represent a swan or the act of holding a flower. Along with facial expressions, eye movements and body posture, mudras form the language of the dance.

Other Classical Dance Forms

Kathak is the classical dance of north India, with the word coming from "katha", meaning story; it features fast rhythmic footwork with ankle bells, spins called chakkars, and graceful gestures, and it has three schools, or gharanas: Jaipur, Lucknow and Benares. Pandit Birju Maharaj was a legendary Kathak dancer. Kuchipudi from Andhra Pradesh is a dance-drama tradition with fast footwork and graceful movements, and a unique feature is dancing on the rim of a brass plate. Odissi from Odisha is known for its flowing, sculpture-like poses, particularly the tribhanga (three-bend) posture, and it was inspired by the temples of Konark and Bhubaneswar. Kathakali from Kerala is a dramatic dance-theatre with elaborate face makeup, colourful costumes and headgear, in which stories from the Mahabharata and Ramayana are told only with gestures, eye movements and facial expressions, with songs sung by singers. Mohiniyattam, also from Kerala, is a graceful solo dance performed by women, with slow swaying movements. Manipuri from Manipur is a soft, lyrical dance, often showing the Raslila of Radha and Krishna, with performers in long skirts. Sattriya of Assam developed in the 15th century in Vaishnavite monasteries called sattras, under the saint Srimanta Sankaradeva.

Folk and Other Dances of Tamil Nadu

Besides Bharatanatyam, Tamil Nadu has colourful folk dances such as Karagattam, in which dancers balance a pot on their heads, Oyilattam, Kummi, Kolattam (stick dance), Poikkal Kudirai Attam (dummy horse dance), Mayilattam (peacock dance) and the street-theatre Therukoothu. Chennai holds large dance festivals each December and January along with the Music Season.

Training, Institutions and Recognition

Training is traditionally through the guru-shishya parampara (teacher-student tradition), with years of practice. Important institutions include Kalakshetra Foundation in Chennai, Kerala Kalamandalam, and the Sangeet Natak Akademi, founded in 1952. India's highest awards for dance include the Sangeet Natak Akademi Award and Padma awards. World Dance Day is celebrated on 29 April.

Challenges and Future

Challenges include shrinking patronage and the need to keep the tradition authentic while experimenting. Today, classical dance is taught in schools, on online platforms and around the world, and dancers explore new themes such as environment and social issues.

Quick Facts

- The Sangeet Natak Akademi recognises eight classical dances: Bharatanatyam, Kathak, Kuchipudi, Odissi, Kathakali, Sattriya, Manipuri and Mohiniyattam.

- Bharatanatyam is the classical dance of Tamil Nadu; Rukmini Devi Arundale founded Kalakshetra in 1936.
- A mudra is a symbolic hand gesture used to express meaning.
- The Natya Shastra by Bharata Muni is the ancient foundation text of Indian dance.
- Sattriya was recognised in 2000.